Kitchen *& Kettle*

Survival Garden Basics

THROW IT IN THE GROUND. IT GROWS.

The easiest, most nourishing crops you can grow — no seed starting, no greenhouse, no fuss. Just good food from good dirt.

You don't need a greenhouse to feed yourself.

You don't need a greenhouse. You don't need seed trays. You don't need grow lights.

A survival garden isn't about growing everything. It's about growing the right things — crops that feed you reliably, store well, and don't demand much. The plants in this guide are the ones that have kept people fed for centuries without any special equipment.

This is not a guide to growing prize-winning tomatoes or exotic herbs. It's a guide to putting food on the table from your own dirt — beans, potatoes, squash, and a handful of other crops that want to grow. The philosophy is simple: if it needs a greenhouse, a heating mat, and daily attention, it's not in this guide.

What you actually need

- **A patch of ground.** Doesn't need to be big. A 10×10 foot plot can produce a surprising amount of food. Even a few large containers on a patio will work for most of these crops.
- **Sunlight.** At least 6 hours of direct sun for most crops. If you have less, stick with leafy greens — they're more forgiving.
- **Water.** A hose or watering can. Consistent water is more important than perfect soil. These crops are forgiving, but nothing grows in dust.
- **Seeds or seed potatoes.** All of the crops in this guide are direct-sown — you put the seed in the ground where it will grow. No transplanting.

HONEST NOTE

A "survival garden" is not a guarantee against disaster. It's a hedge. It means that if food gets expensive, you have beans and potatoes. If the store runs short, you have squash in the cellar. It's not a replacement for grocery stores — it's a backup that also happens to give you the best-tasting vegetables you'll ever eat.

> *These crops grow across temperate climates worldwide — Canada to Texas to France. What changes is timing: use your local frost dates, not the calendar. In very short seasons, choose fast-maturing varieties. In blazing summers, grow cool-season crops in fall and winter instead of spring. When in doubt, your local extension office knows your dirt better than any book.*

The Easiest, Most Nourishing Crops

> *All of these go directly in the ground. No seed starting. No greenhouse. No special treatment.*

Beans (bush and pole)

DIRECT SOW · WARM SOIL · 50–65 DAYS

Why they're essential: High protein, easy to dry and store for years, and they improve your soil by fixing nitrogen. Bush beans need no support. Pole beans need a trellis but produce more per square foot.

How: Push seeds 1 inch into warm soil (after last frost). Space 4 inches apart. Water. They come up fast. For dry beans, leave pods on the plant until they rattle.

Potatoes

SEED POTATOES · COOL SOIL · 70–120 DAYS

Why they're essential: More calories per square foot than almost any other crop. Store for months in a cool dark place. A 10×10 foot plot can produce 50–100 pounds.

How: Seed potatoes aren't botanical seeds — they're potatoes grown for planting, certified disease-free and never treated with sprout inhibitors (grocery store potatoes often are, which is why pantry potatoes sometimes won't grow). Cut them into chunks with 2–3 eyes each. Bury 4 inches deep, 12 inches apart. Hill soil around the stems as they grow. Harvest when the tops die back.

Winter squash

DIRECT SOW · WARM SOIL · 80–110 DAYS

Why it's essential: Stores for months at room temperature. One butternut squash plant can produce 5–10 squash. Dense, sweet, versatile — soups, roasting, pies, bread.

How: Plant seeds in small hills (3–4 seeds per hill) after frost danger passes. Thin to the strongest 2 plants per hill. Give them room — they sprawl. Harvest when the skin is hard and the stem is dry.

Zucchini / Summer Squash

DIRECT SOW · WARM SOIL · 45–55 DAYS

Why it's essential: The most reliable producer in the garden. Two plants will keep a family in squash all summer. Fast, easy, and nearly impossible to kill. You will give some away. This is not a warning — it's a promise.

How: Plant seeds directly in warm soil after frost. Give them space — 24 inches apart. Pick small (6–8 inches) for best texture. If you miss one, it becomes a baseball bat overnight.

More Crops Worth the Space

Kale

DIRECT SOW · COOL SEASON · 50–65 DAYS

Cold-hardy, survives frost, actually tastes better after a freeze. Pick outer leaves and the plant keeps producing for months. One of the most nutritious leafy greens you can grow.

How: Scatter seeds, cover lightly with soil, keep moist. Thin seedlings to 12 inches apart.

Swiss Chard

DIRECT SOW · COOL OR WARM · 50–60 DAYS

More heat-tolerant than kale, less likely to bolt. Produces continuously when you harvest outer leaves. Beautiful in the garden — bright stems in yellow, red, pink. Tastes like a mild spinach.

How: Same as kale. Soak seeds overnight to speed germination.

Garlic

PLANT CLOVES · FALL · 8–9 MONTHS

Plant in fall, mulch heavily, harvest in summer. The lowest-effort crop in existence — you literally put a clove in the ground and come back next year. Stores for months. Every kitchen needs it.

How: Break apart a head of garlic. Plant individual cloves pointy-side-up, 2 inches deep, 6 inches apart. Mulch with straw. Harvest when the lower leaves turn brown.

Carrots

DIRECT SOW · COOL SEASON · 55–75 DAYS

The trick is loose soil — carrots need to push down. If your soil is heavy clay, grow shorter varieties (like Chantenay) or grow them in a deep container. Once they sprout, they need almost nothing. Store in sand or in the ground over winter.

How: Sow seeds very shallow (¼ inch) and keep moist until germination — this is the hardest part. Thin to 2 inches apart once they're a few inches tall.

More Crops Worth the Space (cont.)

> *Same rule: all direct-sown. No seed starting. No special treatment.*

Beets

DIRECT SOW · COOL SEASON · 50–70 DAYS

Two crops in one: the roots store for months in a cool place, and the greens are tender and sweet — cook them like chard. Beets germinate in cool soil and handle light frost. Thin them once and they take care of themselves.

How: Soak seeds overnight to speed germination. Sow ½ inch deep, 2 inches apart. Thin to 3–4 inches when seedlings are a few inches tall. Harvest roots at golf-ball to tennis-ball size for best texture.

Corn

DIRECT SOW · WARM SOIL · 60–100 DAYS

Calorie-dense and stores indefinitely when dried and shelled. One of the original survival crops alongside beans and squash — the three were grown together for centuries. Plant in blocks (not a single row) so the wind can pollinate the silks properly.

How: Sow 1 inch deep, 8–12 inches apart, in blocks of at least 4 rows. Wait until soil is warm — corn hates cold feet. Harvest when silks are brown and dry, and kernels release milky juice when pressed.

Radishes

DIRECT SOW · COOL SEASON · 25–35 DAYS

The fastest crop in the garden. From seed to harvest in under a month. Plant a small patch every two weeks for a continuous supply. If you're new to gardening, start here — the quick win builds confidence. Spicy, crisp, great raw or pickled.

How: Scatter seeds ½ inch deep, 1 inch apart. Thin to 2 inches. Keep moist. Harvest promptly — radishes left too long turn woody and hot. The greens are edible too.

Turnips

DIRECT SOW · COOL SEASON · 40–60 DAYS

A traditional survival staple for good reason: roots store for months in a root cellar, and the greens are one of the most nutritious leafy vegetables you can grow. Plant in late summer for a fall harvest that holds in the ground through light frosts.

How: Sow ¼ inch deep, 2 inches apart. Thin to 4–6 inches. Keep watered — dry soil makes woody roots. Harvest roots at 2–3 inches across for tenderness. Greens can be picked anytime.

More Crops Worth the Space (cont.)

> *Warm-season sprawlers. Give them room and sun, and they'll feed you all summer.*

Cantaloupe / Muskmelon

DIRECT SOW · WARM SOIL · 70–90 DAYS

Sweet, fragrant, and nothing like store-bought. Needs heat and sun — the warmer the summer, the better the flavor. One plant can produce 4–6 melons. The sign they're ready: the stem slips cleanly from the fruit with a gentle tug.

How: Plant seeds in small hills (3–4 per hill) after soil is warm. Thin to the 2 strongest. Vines run 6+ feet — give them room or train them up a trellis. Mulch under developing fruit to prevent rot. Stop watering a week before harvest for sweeter melons.

Watermelon

DIRECT SOW · WARM SOIL · 75–100 DAYS

Needs more space and a longer season than cantaloupe, but pays it back. A single healthy vine can produce 2–3 full-size melons. Choose shorter-season varieties if your summers aren't long — 'Sugar Baby' matures in 75 days.

How: Same as cantaloupe — hills, warm soil, room to sprawl. Water consistently while fruit is developing. Harvest when the underside spot turns from white to creamy yellow and the tendril nearest the fruit dries out and turns brown.

How to Plant — The Only Rules That Matter

1. Prepare the ground (once)

- Remove grass and weeds from your planting area. A shovel or hoe is all you need.
- Loosen the soil 6–8 inches deep. Don't overthink it — a garden fork or shovel works fine.
- If your soil is poor, mix in compost. If you don't have compost, just plant anyway. These crops are forgiving.

2. Plant at the right time

- **Cool-season crops** (kale, chard, carrots, garlic, potatoes): plant in early spring or fall. They handle light frost.
- **Warm-season crops** (beans, squash, zucchini): plant after your last frost date when soil is warm. If you're not sure, wait an extra week.
- **Garlic:** plant in fall, about 4–6 weeks before the ground freezes. Mulch heavily.

3. Water consistently

- Seeds need consistent moisture to germinate. Water gently every day or two until sprouts appear.
- Once established, most crops do fine with a deep watering 2–3 times a week rather than daily sprinkles.
- Water the soil, not the leaves — wet leaves invite disease. Water in the morning if you can.

4. Mulch everything

- Cover bare soil with straw, grass clippings, shredded leaves, or even cardboard.
- Mulch holds moisture, suppresses weeds, and feeds the soil as it breaks down.
- This is the closest thing to a gardening cheat code. Do it. You'll water less and weed almost never.

Harvesting and Storage

> *How to bring it in and keep it good — every crop in this guide.*

- **Beans (fresh):** Pick young, while pods are still tender. Refrigerate up to a week. Blanch and freeze for longer storage.
- **Beans (dry):** Let pods fully dry on the plant until they rattle. Shell and store in glass jars in a cool, dark place — they keep for years.
- **Potatoes:** Harvest after the tops die back. Cure in a dark, cool spot for 1–2 weeks, then store in burlap or paper bags (not plastic) in a cool, dark place. Don't wash until you're ready to use them.
- **Winter squash:** Harvest when the skin is hard — your fingernail shouldn't dent it. Leave 2 inches of stem attached. Cure in a warm, dry spot for 1–2 weeks, then store at room temperature on a shelf or in a cupboard. Keeps for months.
- **Zucchini / summer squash:** Pick at 6–8 inches for best texture. Check daily — they hide and become baseball bats overnight. Refrigerate up to a week. Grate and freeze for baking; slice and dehydrate for soup add-ins.
- **Corn:** Harvest when silks are brown and dry, and kernels release milky juice when pressed with a thumbnail. Eat immediately for best sweetness — sugar converts to starch within hours of picking. Blanch and freeze, or leave on the stalk to dry fully for cornmeal and winter storage.
- **Garlic:** Harvest when the lower leaves turn brown (about half the plant). Cure by hanging in a dry, airy spot for 2–3 weeks. Trim roots and tops, then store in a cool, dark place — not the fridge. Save your best heads to replant in fall.

Harvesting and Storage (cont.)

- **Cantaloupe:** Harvest when the stem slips cleanly from the fruit with a gentle tug — if you have to pull, it's not ready. Refrigerate up to a week. The ones you grow yourself will be sweeter and more fragrant than anything from a store.
- **Watermelon:** Harvest when the underside spot turns from white to creamy yellow and the tendril nearest the fruit dries out and turns brown. Store whole at cool room temperature for 2–3 weeks. Refrigerate after cutting.
- **Kale:** Pick outer leaves from the bottom; the plant keeps producing from the center for months. Actually tastes sweeter after a frost. Refrigerate 1–2 weeks. Blanch and freeze for long storage — one of the few greens that freezes well.
- **Swiss chard:** Same as kale — harvest outer leaves continuously. Refrigerate up to a week. Blanch and freeze. More heat-tolerant than kale, so it produces longer into summer.
- **Carrots:** Harvest when the shoulders push up through the soil surface. Leave in the ground over winter under a thick straw mulch and dig as needed — they sweeten in cold soil. Or store in damp sand or sawdust in a cool place for months. Remove tops before storing — they pull moisture from the root.

Harvesting and Storage (cont.)

- **Beets:** Harvest at golf-ball to tennis-ball size for best texture. Cut tops to 1 inch before storing — the greens are tender and sweet, cook them like chard. Roots store for months in damp sand in a cool place.
- **Radishes:** Harvest promptly at about 1 inch across — left too long they turn woody and hot. Refrigerate 1–2 weeks. Plant a new patch every two weeks for a continuous supply. The greens are edible too.
- **Turnips:** Harvest roots at 2–3 inches across for tenderness. Store in damp sand in a root cellar for months — a traditional winter staple. Greens can be picked anytime during the growing season.
- **Asparagus:** Cut or snap spears at ground level when 6–8 inches tall. Stop harvesting by early summer to let the plants rebuild for next year. Refrigerate upright in a jar with an inch of water (like cut flowers) for up to a week. Blanch and freeze.
- **Strawberries:** Pick when fully red all over — they don't ripen after picking. Refrigerate 2–3 days max, unwashed. Freeze whole on a tray until solid, then transfer to a bag. Or make jam — June-bearing varieties give you enough all at once to make a batch.
- **Rhubarb:** Pull stalks with a slight twist — never cut, as cut stems invite rot. Only eat the stalks; leaves are toxic. Stop harvesting by mid-summer. Refrigerate up to a week. Chop and freeze raw for winter pies and crisps.

Harvesting and Storage (cont.)

- **Perennial herbs:** Cut sprigs as needed — plants get bushier in response. For storage, dry by hanging small bundles in a dark, airy spot until leaves crumble. Store in glass jars away from light. Or freeze chopped herbs in olive oil in an ice cube tray — drop a cube into a pan and you have instant flavor.
- **Figs:** Harvest when soft to the touch and drooping slightly on the branch — they don't ripen once picked. Refrigerate 2–3 days max. Dry them (halved, in a low oven or dehydrator) for months of storage, or make preserves.
- **Blueberries:** Harvest when deep blue with a powdery white bloom. They ripen over several weeks — pick every few days. Refrigerate up to 2 weeks, unwashed. Freeze whole on a tray until solid, then bag. Net your bushes before the fruit turns blue — birds will strip them the morning you planned to pick.
- **Sour cherries:** Harvest when deep red and slightly soft. Refrigerate up to a week. Pit and freeze on trays, or turn into preserves and pie filling. One mature dwarf tree gives you enough for a year of pies.
- **Raspberries & blackberries:** Harvest when they pull easily from the core — if you have to tug, wait another day. Refrigerate 2–3 days max, unwashed, in a single layer (they crush easily). Freeze whole on a tray, then bag. Pick every other day during peak season — they come fast.

Plant Once, Harvest for Years

> *Plant them once. They come back every year, bigger and better, while you do nothing.*

Asparagus

PLANT CROWNS · PERENNIAL · HARVEST YEAR 3

The ultimate long game. A well-planted asparagus bed produces for 20 years or more. You can't harvest until year three — the plants need time to build root systems — but after that you'll cut spears every spring for two decades.

How: Buy 1-year-old crowns (not seeds). Dig a trench 8 inches deep, set crowns 12 inches apart, cover with 2 inches of soil. Fill the trench gradually as spears grow. Mulch heavily. Don't harvest until year 3; stop by early summer to let plants recharge.

Strawberries

PLANT CROWNS · PERENNIAL · HARVEST YEAR 2

June-bearing varieties give you a big harvest all at once — perfect for jam and freezing. Everbearing spread the harvest across the season. Plants send out runners and fill in the bed on their own; thin the oldest every 3–4 years and let the younger ones take over.

How: Plant crowns in early spring, 12–18 inches apart, crown at soil level (not buried). Mulch with straw. First year, pinch off flowers to let plants establish. Harvest freely year 2 and beyond.

Plant Once, Harvest for Years (cont.)

Perennial Herbs

PLANT STARTS · PERENNIAL · HARVEST YEAR 1

Rosemary, thyme, oregano, sage, chives — Mediterranean herbs that thrive on neglect. Sun, decent drainage, and leave them alone. Most get bigger and better every year. Chives are the earliest green in spring. Mint is perennial too, but keep it in a container — it will take over.

How: Buy small plants (herbs from seed are slow). Plant in a sunny spot, water until established, then mostly ignore. Harvest by cutting sprigs — plants get bushier in response. In cold climates, mulch rosemary and sage in fall.

Rhubarb

PLANT CROWNS · PERENNIAL · HARVEST YEAR 2

Once established, rhubarb is nearly unkillable. Thrives in cool climates, comes back bigger each year, produces for 10–15 years. The stalks are tart and excellent for pies, crisps, and preserves. Warning: leaves are toxic — only eat the stalks.

How: Plant crowns in early spring, 3 feet apart (they get large). Buds just at soil level. Mulch with compost each fall. Harvest by pulling stalks with a slight twist — never cut. Stop by mid-summer to let the plant rebuild for next year.

Growing Out Your Orchard

> *Multi-year projects that pay off for a decade or more. Plant them once, wait, then harvest more than you can carry.*

These aren't the fast wins of beans and zucchini. These are the long game — fruit trees and bushes that take a few years to establish, then produce reliably for a decade or longer. All of these are self-pollinating, which means you only need one plant to get fruit. No second tree required for cross-pollination — though the bees will still show up for the flowers.

Fig Tree

PLANT DORMANT TREE · SELF-POLLINATING · HARVEST YEAR 2–3

The easiest fruit tree you can grow. Figs are self-pollinating (the flowers are inside the fruit), thrive in large containers, and need almost no pruning. A mature fig can produce 20–50 pounds per year. In cold climates, grow in a pot and overwinter indoors or wrap in burlap.

How: Plant in spring, full sun. Figs tolerate poor soil but need good drainage. Water deeply while establishing; once mature, they're drought-tolerant. Prune only to remove dead wood. Harvest when fruit is soft and droops slightly.

Blueberry Bushes

PLANT BARE-ROOT · SELF-POLLINATING · HARVEST YEAR 2–3

Many varieties are self-fertile, though planting two different types improves yield. A single mature bush produces 5–10 pounds of berries. Blueberries need acidic soil (pH 4.5–5.5) — if your soil isn't naturally acidic, grow them in large containers with ericaceous compost.

How: Plant in early spring, full sun, 4–5 feet apart. Mulch heavily with pine bark or sawdust to maintain acidity. Water consistently — shallow roots dry out fast. First two years, remove flowers to let the bush establish. Net against birds when fruit ripens.

Growing Out Your Orchard (cont.)

Dwarf Sour Cherry

PLANT BARE-ROOT · SELF-POLLINATING · HARVEST YEAR 3–4

Sour cherries (like Montmorency) are self-pollinating and far more cold-hardy than sweet cherries. A dwarf variety on rootstock stays 8–12 feet — manageable for a home garden. One mature tree can produce 30–50 pounds. Excellent for pies, preserves, and drying.

How: Plant in full sun with good air circulation. Dig a hole twice as wide as the roots. Water deeply for the first two years. Prune in late winter to keep an open center. Harvest when fruit is deep red and slightly soft.

Raspberries & Blackberries

PLANT CANES · SELF-POLLINATING · HARVEST YEAR 2

The closest thing to instant gratification in the orchard section. Plant bare-root canes in spring and you'll get a modest harvest the following year, with full production by year 3. Both spread on their own — a row of 10 canes becomes a hedge. Summer-bearing and everbearing varieties available.

How: Plant canes 2 feet apart in a row, full sun. Trellis for easier picking — a simple wire between posts does it. Cut summer-bearing canes to the ground after they fruit. Everbearing: cut all canes to the ground in late winter for a single fall crop. Mulch heavily.

> *Fruit trees and bushes are the ultimate survival crop — they produce more food per square foot per year than anything else in this guide, and they do it for decades. The catch is patience. Plant them this year, even if you're not sure you'll be in the same house in five years. Future you will be glad you did.*

Quick Reference

The easiest five

- **Beans** — protein, stores dry for years
- **Potatoes** — most calories per square foot
- **Winter squash** — stores months at room temp
- **Zucchini** — fastest, most reliable producer
- **Garlic** — plant in fall, forget, harvest in summer

More easy crops

- **Beets** — roots + greens, thin once and done
- **Corn** — calorie-dense, stores dry, plant in blocks
- **Melons** — cantaloupe and watermelon, need sun and space
- **Radishes** — fastest crop, 25 days seed to harvest
- **Turnips** — roots + greens, traditional survival staple

Cool vs. warm season

- **Cool (early spring / fall):** kale, chard, carrots, beets, radishes, turnips, garlic, potatoes
- **Warm (after last frost):** beans, corn, squash, zucchini, melons

Quick Reference (cont.)

What you don't need

- Seed-starting trays or grow lights
- A greenhouse or cold frame
- Perfect soil — these crops grow in average dirt
- Daily attention — mulch does half the work

One thing that makes everything easier

- Mulch. Straw, grass clippings, leaves, cardboard. Cover bare soil. You'll water less, weed less, and your soil improves every year.

Plant once, harvest for years

- **Asparagus** — 20+ year bed, harvest from year 3
- **Strawberries** — spread on their own, harvest from year 2
- **Perennial herbs** — rosemary, thyme, oregano, sage, chives
- **Rhubarb** — 10–15 years, nearly unkillable (stalks only)
- **Fruit trees & bushes:** figs, blueberries, sour cherry, raspberries — see Orchard section

Garden Notes

Track what you planted, what worked, and what you'll do differently next year.

WHAT I PLANTED THIS YEAR

FIRST AND LAST FROST DATES

WHAT GREW WELL / WHAT DIDN'T

HARVEST LOG AND STORAGE NOTES

A note on growing food

Gardening is not a test. If half your seeds don't come up, you're not a failure — you're a gardener. Plant extra. Some will make it. Some won't. The ones that do will feed you.

Start small. A 4×8 foot bed with beans, potatoes, and a squash plant will produce more than you expect. Add a few more crops next year. The best garden is the one you actually manage to plant and harvest — not the ambitious plan you sketch in January and abandon by June.

The crops in this guide want to grow. Give them dirt, sun, water, and mulch. They'll do the rest.

Grow what you eat

You don't need acreage. A few square feet of good soil, the right plants for your climate, and a willingness to let some things fail — that's the whole system. The garden that feeds you isn't the one that looks perfect. It's the one you actually tend.

Works because it works.